



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

THAT'S A WRAP FOR WORLD CUP IN L.A.

Spain fans celebrate after their team defeated Belgium 2-1 in a World Cup quarterfinal Friday, the last match of the tournament held at SoFi Stadium, played in front of another sellout crowd. **SPORTS, B12**

Fatal ICE shooting in Texas under scrutiny

Homeland Security claims self-defense, but three witnesses dispute that account.

By Andrea Castillo

WASHINGTON — The fatal shooting this week of Lorenzo Salgado Araujo, a Mexican immigrant and home builder who was driving his construction crew to a Houston job site, is at least the eighth such death amid the Trump administration's mass deportation campaign.

The death of Salgado Araujo, a husband and father of three U.S. citizens who had been in the country for 35 years, led to protests in Houston and calls for an independent investigation. Advocates for immigrants called attention to the fact that his death hasn't resulted in the widespread anger that roiled the country after two U.S. citizens were shot and killed by federal agents in Minneapolis.

Federal officers were looking for someone else when they attempted to stop Salgado Araujo's vehicle, according to the Department of Homeland Security, which oversees ICE. The department alleges that he rammed an ICE vehicle, refused to follow commands and attempted to run over an ICE officer, causing the officer to open fire in self-defense.

But the three passengers in his vehicle — one of whom is Salgado Araujo's brother — who were detained and taken to the Montgomery Processing Center in Conroe, Texas, disputed ICE's account. During a news conference Friday, their attorney said, "We are not aware of any evidence that would suggest that Mr. Salgado Araujo was a threat to anyone."

Trump purges bipartisan election commission

Voting experts and others say the move aims to undermine free and fair balloting.

By Kevin Rector and Ana Ceballos

WASHINGTON — President Trump dismissed all remaining members of the bipartisan U.S. Election Assistance Commission this week, his latest move to assert control over national elections in the final months before midterm voting.

The White House defended the move as justified by a recent U.S. Supreme Court decision handing the president greater authority to reshape independent government agencies, including by replacing appointed leaders.

Democrats and some independent elections experts blasted it as politically motivated, counter to the interests of voters and foolhardy with the November election so close.

"Purging commissioners just months before the midterm elections and further gutting support for our state and local elections officials is a blatant part of his plan to politicize our elections and enable more unlawful and dangerous election interference," said Sen. Alex Padilla (D-Calif.), the top Democrat on the Senate Rules Committee, which oversees federal elections.

Padilla alleged the dismissals are an attempt by Trump "to dismantle yet another independent guardrail of our democracy designed to keep elections fair and secure."

A White House official framed the dismissals in starkly different terms, saying the departing commissioners were "not totally aligned with the important task of securing America's elections and ensuring every legal vote is counted."

It did not say when the president planned to appoint new commissioners. The four-member commission was created by Congress in 2002 as part of the Help America Vote Act to help states improve their voting systems and voter access. By law, no more than two commissioners may be dismissed.

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Feds clear path for Mojave pipeline

Plan to pump groundwater is seen as a threat to wildlife and springs

By Ian James



AL SEIB Los Angeles Times

CADIZ, which operates the basin above, plans to convert a pipeline previously used for oil and gas.

The Trump administration has signed off on a company's plan to convert an oil and gas pipeline to pump groundwater from the Mojave Desert to thirsty California cities for the first time, a lucrative venture that critics say threatens natural springs and wildlife.

The federal Bureau of Land Management released documents Thursday saying that Cadiz Inc.'s plan to repurpose 162 miles of the pipeline to transport water "will not significantly affect" the environment.

"We're excited to achieve this pivotal milestone. After many years of planning and environmental review, the project has now reached the construction stage," said Susan Kennedy, chair and chief executive of Cadiz.

Environmental advocates and leaders of Native tribes, who have been fighting the project, criticized the decision.

"This groundwater mining proposal would drain the desert and rob the Mojave of its rare springs and wildlife habitat," said Chance Wilcox, California desert activist.

Safety issues seen long before fire in Boyle Heights

Warehouse operator asked city to look into removing device from rooftop solar panels.

By Alex Wigglesworth

A year before a massive fire at a Boyle Heights cold storage building sent polluted smoke into surrounding communities, the operator of the facility came to Los Angeles City Hall with a request.

Lineage asked about removing an emergency shutdown switch from the solar panels on the roof of the structure, according to the Los Angeles Department of Building and Safety.

A spokesperson for Lineage said that the company was inquiring about what it described as a safer alternative to rapid shutdown devices. Though intended to protect firefighters from shock, some shutdown devices have also been linked to increased fire risk.

Ultimately, the company did not receive any variances or exemptions as a result of its efforts, the spokesperson said.

Neither Lineage nor the city would provide any details about what kind of shutdown system was in place at the time of the fire.

Eastside residents vent frustration

L.A. officials, Lineage executive are confronted at Boyle Heights town hall about warehouse fire cleanup. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Altus Power, which owns the solar panels, declined to specify, citing the ongoing investigation into the blaze.

But the solar panels have become a focus of the fire. According to Lineage, company officials believe the fire began while third-party subcontractors were testing the rooftop solar array at the nearly 500,000-square-foot warehouse.

The Los Angeles Fire Department has not announced what caused the blaze.

The state code requires that rooftop solar arrays have rapid shutdown systems that quickly reduce the voltage to a level that makes it safe for first responders to access a roof in an emergency.

The systems are typically activated by a switch, which communicates with rapid shutdown devices to reduce the voltage to the panels, said Ryan Mayfield, chief engineer and founder of Mayfield Renewables, which specializes in solar panel safety.

Nail salon duo face grand theft charges

Vietnamese investors allege that more than \$1 million was stolen in their community.

By Matthew Ormseth

In the San Fernando Valley's tight-knit Vietnamese community, Thien "Kim" Nguyen was known as a successful entrepreneur.

She ran a nail salon in Canoga Park and spoke of dabbling in lucrative sidelines — a car dealership, an import-export business, real estate investments, according to Hua Ma, a San Fernando Valley resident who went into business with Nguyen.

So when Nguyen asked Hua Ma to invest in her nail salon, he agreed.

Ma was enticed by a promise of quick returns and

encouraged by what seemed like trappings of success, he said in an interview: Nguyen wore Chanel sunglasses, dressed in designer clothes and drove a Tesla. But what clinched the deal, he said, was the fact he'd known Nguyen's husband and his extended family for years.

"In our culture, you want to know someone, know their family," Ma said.

Ma brought a bundle of \$100 bills to Nguyen's home in Winnetka, where he took pictures of Nguyen and her husband counting the cash at their dining table, according to Ma and photographs reviewed by The Times. Between multiple instances, Ma lent the couple \$105,000 in all, a Los Angeles Police Department detective wrote in an affidavit supporting charges against Nguyen and her husband, Phuc Huynh.

But after receiving three

World Cup joy drove a return to roots in Mexico

During El Tri's run, diaspora in U.S. looked southward for acceptance

By Alfredo Corchado

MEXICO CITY — Mexico's improbable World Cup run ended Sunday with a loss to England, but it didn't keep the team's heart and tenacity from delivering one success: a notable increase in Mexican Americans venturing south to reconnect with their roots, language and culture, according to longtime observers and travel figures.

The trend, which emerged long before the World Cup, gained intensity against the backdrop of uncertainty in the United States generated by what many see as an anti-immigrant climate fueled by the Trump administration's crackdown on immigration.

A sense of being targeted is palpable across the United States in Mexican American communities from Los Angeles to El Paso and among U.S. Latinos interviewed in

Mexico City.

Even so, as Mexico advanced through the tournament, an indicator of national pride emerged: record-setting sales of FIFA Mexico jerseys. More than 5 million were sold — half of them in the United States.

"Putting on the Mexican jersey this time took on a different meaning," said Leny Hernandez, 32, a businessman and former combat soldier, after Mexico's elimination from the tournament. "I

don't see this as a defeat, but as a victory. I still believe in the dream."

While demographic data don't pinpoint how many Latinos or Mexican Americans travel annually to Mexico, the travel site Road Genius said almost 5 million of the 48 million foreign visitors to the country went in December, which is traditionally when Mexican Americans return for religious celebrations and vacation.

[See Mexico, A3]



IRFAN KHAN Los Angeles Times

FAMED STUDIO FOR SALE

Television City, among the most desirable properties in L.A., expected to hit the market while owners sell another historic site. **BUSINESS, A10**

Trump post stirs claims of bigotry

Minnesota officials and residents say anti-Muslim video may put kindergartners at risk. **NATION, A4**

Weather

Clouds and sun. L.A. Basin: 82/65. **B8**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

1 million women lose aid globally

Groups report rise in unmet needs since USAID was slashed, U.N. says. **WORLD, A2**

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